

Our current project plan

A project charter is a plan that explains the goal, limits, people, risks, and next steps for a project. | Course: CS 4390 and CS 5388 Software Project Management | Date: September 2026 | Current stage: Validation through prototype evaluation

What we chose and why

The team selected a real-time campus dining availability system after comparing food availability, dining hours and service status, meal-plan rollover, customizable meal plans, and dining alerts. The selected direction is to test current status information for dining items, stations, kitchens, counters, and temporary service changes.

- 12 focused availability interviews: primary evidence for the current direction.
- 13 meal-plan preference responses: background from the earlier direction, not validation for the availability system.
- Five candidate ideas: options compared before the project was narrowed.

The problem we want to solve

Students sometimes arrive at a campus dining location and discover that an item, station, kitchen service, counter, or required option is unavailable. When earlier information does not show the change, they may lose time, substitute a meal, remain hungry, or spend more than planned.

The first business objective is to find out whether current information can help students avoid wasted trips, delays, substitutions, and unexpected spending when they decide where to eat on campus.

What this project does and does not include

Included now

- 13 additional focused interviews
- Requirements for what the tool must do
- Clear meanings for each status
- A process for updating and checking information
- Simple and interactive test versions
- Tests with students and a review of what is realistic

Not included now

- A finished website or mobile app
- Live connections to UTEP or vendor systems
- A promise that every update will be instant
- Changes to staff, policy, pricing, payment, or rollover
- Replacement of official systems
- Promises from staff or vendors who have not approved them

Saved for later

- Building the finished application
- Connections to menu, inventory, or sales systems
- Notifications and user accounts
- Usage reports and staff controls
- A small test launch or campus-wide launch

- Decisions about who would run the service

What we plan to do next

- Validation: reach 25 focused availability interviews and decide whether the problem is repeated, specific, and costly enough to continue.
- Requirements: rank needed status changes, define freshness, and identify who could report and verify each change.
- Prototype: build a testable flow that shows location, availability, status details, and when information was updated.
- Usability and feasibility: test with students and review operational limits before considering a pilot proposal.

What needs to be true for the idea to work

- Students will check availability before walking to a dining location.
- Available, Low Stock, Sold Out, Closed, and Service Outage will be clear enough to support a decision.
- Availability can be updated often enough to remain useful.
- An approved source can report changes without excessive work.
- Students from different groups experience the problem.
- The project can show stale or uncertain information honestly.

People affected and team responsibilities

Stakeholder	Interest or responsibility	Influence
Students	Use dining information and provide research and usability feedback	High
Commuter students	May have limited time between classes	High
Students living on campus	May use several dining locations often	High
Graduate students	May have varied schedules	Medium
Campus dining administration	Reviews feasibility, ownership, and staff work	High
Dining locations and vendors	May supply or verify status information	High
UTEP administration and technology teams	Would review policy, access, security, and integration	High
Team 10	Conducts research, defines requirements, prototypes, and evaluates results	High

Zachary Carrejo focuses on website and documentation. Salvador Rodarte supports interviews, research synthesis, charter work, and prototype development. Daniel Lozano supports requirements, data design, documentation, and technical development. Jacob Ordonez supports the website and prototype. Team 10 shares charter decisions.

What could go wrong and how we would respond

- Stale information: show update times, define stale states, and test verification paths.
- Staff workload: test the shortest update flow and compare possible reporting approaches.
- No live-system access: use realistic sample data and document integration questions.
- Research sample bias: recruit across student types, schedules, and dining locations.
- Scope growth: use this boundary and record requests before adding work.
- Unclear ownership: do not recommend a pilot until reporting, verification, and correction responsibilities are documented.
- Accessibility and privacy: use readable labels, keyboard-friendly interactions, color-independent cues, and minimal participant data.

How we will decide whether to continue

- Reach 25 focused availability interviews while keeping meal-plan responses separate.
- Document each status, data source, owner, freshness expectation, and state-state behavior.
- Let a student identify whether an item or service is Available, Low Stock, Sold Out, Closed, or affected by a Service Outage.
- Test with at least five participants, with at least four completing the main task without help.
- Document a realistic update owner, workflow, and data source before recommending a pilot.

Who makes decisions and what is still open

Team 10 reviews research findings and scope changes together because no project lead has been chosen and responsibility is shared.

- Which changes are important enough to publish or notify?
- How quickly must each type of information be updated?
- Who can report and verify a change without excessive staff work?
- Should value be measured through time saved, cost avoided, or fewer disrupted meals?